

Rootless voicings: Major ii-V-I all keys



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Your challenge: To play the ii-V-I through all 12 keys, note-perfectly, three times in a row. If you mess up - start again!

Difficulty level = Medium - advanced (but very important)

PIANO

Dm⁷ G⁷ Cmaj⁷ → C^m⁷ F⁷ B^bmaj⁷ →

Position A Position B Position A

Play both hands up or down an octave as needed

B^bm⁷ E^b⁷ A^bmaj⁷ → A^bm⁷ D^b⁷ G^bmaj⁷ →

F[#]m⁷ B⁷ E⁺maj⁷ → E⁺m⁷ A⁷ D⁺maj⁷ →

Dm⁷ G⁷ Cmaj⁷ C[#]m⁷ F[#]⁷ Bmaj⁷ ➔

(That's the first six keys)

Up a half-step

Bm⁷ E⁷ Amaj⁷ ➔ Am⁷ D⁷ Gmaj⁷ ➔

Gm⁷ C⁷ Fmaj⁷ ➔ Fm⁷ B^b⁷ Ebmaj⁷ ➔

Eb^m⁷ Ab⁷ Dbmaj⁷ ➔ C[#]m⁷ F[#]⁷ Bmaj⁷

That's all 12 keys!

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Now do the same but switch positions. This time play position B - A - B

Difficulty level = Medium

First system of rootless voicings:

- Dm7 (Position B)
- G7 (Position A)
- Cmaj7 (Position B) → Cm7
- F7
- Bbmaj7 →

Play both hands up or down an octave as needed

Second system of rootless voicings:

- Bbm7
- Eb7
- Abmaj7 → Abm7
- Db7
- Gbmaj7 →

Third system of rootless voicings:

- F#m7
- B7
- Emaj7 → Em7
- A7
- Dmaj7 →

Fourth system of rootless voicings:

- Dm7
- G7
- Cmaj7 (That's the first six keys)
- C#m7
- F#7
- Bbmaj7 →

Up a half-step

Three staves of music showing rootless voicings for 12 keys. Each staff contains two measures of a ii-V-I progression. The first staff shows Bm7, E7, Am7, D7, Gmaj7. The second staff shows Gm7, C7, Fmaj7, Bb7, Ebmaj7. The third staff shows Ebm7, Ab7, Dbmaj7, C#m7, F#7, Bbmaj7. Arrows indicate the progression from the first measure to the second measure of each staff.

That's all 12 keys!

"Why is this important?"

Rootless voicings are the quickest way to sound professional.

If you only learn one type of voicing (other than playing 'literal' chord symbols), rootless voicings should be it.

When I was learning Jazz, I noticed a big jump up in my sound when I learned these rootless voicings and applied them to my repertoire.

Expect this to take 2-4 weeks. Practice nothing else. Just the ii-V-I through all 12 keys. Once you can do this, you'll sound professional.

"When do I use rootless voicings?"

Rootless voicings are ideal when the melody note is the 9th:
play position A = 1 / 3 5 7 9 .

Or when the melody note is the 5th:
play position B = 1 / 7 9 3 5 .